



Plans outline deep cuts to health agencies

HHS budget draft pares away billions and seeks to reshape the industry

This article is by *Lena H. Sun, Carolyn Y. Johnson, Rachel Roubein, Joel Achenbach and Lauren Weber*

The Trump administration is seeking to deeply slash budgets for federal health programs, a roughly one-third cut in discretionary

spending by the Department of Health and Human Services, according to a preliminary budget document obtained by The Washington Post.

The HHS budget draft, known as a “passback,” offers the first full look at the health and social service priorities of President Donald Trump’s Office of Management and Budget as it prepares to send his 2026 fiscal year budget request to Congress. It shows how the Trump administration plans to reshape the federal health agencies that oversee food and drug safety, manage the

nation’s response to infectious-disease threats and drive biomedical research.

The 64-page document calls not only for cuts, but also a major shuffling and restructuring of health and human service agencies.

Agencies are allowed to appeal to HHS for changes but have been told they cannot change the bottom line, according to a federal health official who spoke on the condition of anonymity because of the sensitivity of the negotiations.

While Congress often ignores

the president’s budget request, this has not been a typical transition to a new administration. Trump and his allies in Congress have made clear they want to smash the status quo by drastically reducing the size of the federal government and scrubbing it of programs and research efforts seen as wasteful or contrary to administration priorities.

The administration already has downsized HHS by about one-fourth of its workforce, with about 20,000 imminent departures since Trump took office. The Centers for

SEE HHS ON **A7**

Judge to weigh Trump officials for contempt

DEPORTATIONS DIDN’T HALT DESPITE ORDER

Boasberg readies proceedings into ‘willful disregard’

BY **MARIANNE LEVINE, SPENCER S. HSU, SALVADOR RIZZO AND JEREMY ROEBUCK**

Chief U.S. District Judge James E. Boasberg of Washington, D.C., on Wednesday said that he would launch proceedings to determine whether any Trump administration officials defied his order not to remove Venezuelan migrants from the country based on the wartime Alien Enemies Act and should face criminal contempt charges.

“The Constitution does not tolerate willful disobedience of judicial orders — especially by officials of a coordinate branch who have sworn an oath to uphold it,” the judge said in a

written ruling. Allowing political leaders to defy court judgments would make “a solemn mockery” of “the constitution itself,” he said.

Boasberg’s order is the latest development in a broader showdown between the Trump administration and the federal judiciary, which has blocked or slowed many of the White House’s far-reaching actions. The Supreme Court ruled this month that the plaintiffs in the Venezuelan migrants’ case filed their lawsuit in the wrong venue, taking the central legal issues of the case away from Boasberg.

SEE **BOASBERG** ON **A4**

Billionaire nation: Super rich rode to power. Sanders fans mope. **C1**



KIN CHEUNG/AP

Members of For Women Scotland, which brought the case, celebrate in London outside the Supreme Court of the United Kingdom.

U.K. court defines ‘woman’ by birth

Ruling raises questions about protections for transgender people

BY **ANNABELLE TIMSIT**

LONDON — Britain’s highest civil court ruled Wednesday that the definition of “woman” under the country’s gender equality law is based on a person’s sex at birth — a highly anticipated judgment in a case with implications for the protections of

transgender people.

The Supreme Court of the United Kingdom ruled unanimously Wednesday that the terms “woman” and “sex” in the country’s 2010 Equality Act — which bans sex discrimination at work and in society — “refer to a biological woman and biological sex,” said Patrick Hodge, the court’s deputy president.

The ruling has narrow but “important” implications, said Colm O’Cinneide, a professor of constitutional and human rights law at University College London, in that it could affect transgender people’s access to

certain single-sex services and spaces in the United Kingdom.

O’Cinneide said the issue of legally defining sex “has been a battleground,” and as a result, the ruling will probably be seen as “very symbolic, very significant.”

“But in some ways, it’s quite a specific judgment turning on a particular point of statutory interpretation,” he said. “Now, we’ll have to wait and see what the wider symbolic political ramifications of it all is.”

The debate over feminism and transgender rights has been a long-brewing one in the U.K.

The LGB Alliance, which advocates for the rights of lesbians, bisexuals and gay men and intervened in the case as a third party, celebrated the ruling on social media, calling it “a watershed for women and, in particular, lesbians who have seen their rights and identities undermined over the last decade.”

In reading out the judgment, Hodge counseled against interpreting it “as a triumph of one or more groups in our society at the expense of another” — namely, as pitting the rights of people female at birth against

SEE **BRITAIN** ON **A11**

Martin was on Russian state media over 150 times

U.S. attorney nominee did not initially disclose appearances to Senate

BY **SPENCER S. HSU AND AARON SCHAFER**

Hours before President Donald Trump announced U.S. missile strikes on Syria in response to a chemical attack that killed 90 civilians in April 2017, Ed Martin said on the Russian state television network RT America that Syrian President Bashar al-Assad might not be to blame. Instead, Martin told viewers, the situation

was “engineered” in Washington “by the people that want war in Syria.”

In early 2022, Martin told an interviewer on the same arm of RT’s global network that “there’s no evidence” of a Russian military buildup on Ukraine’s borders, criticizing U.S. officials as warmongering and ignoring Russia’s security concerns. Russia invaded nine days later, igniting a war that continues today.

Martin is now interim U.S. attorney for D.C. and Trump’s pick to serve full time in the role. But as a conservative activist and

SEE **MARTIN** ON **A6**

Social media: Justice Department sets limits on employees’ posts. **A3**



Ed Martin, now the interim U.S. attorney for D.C., in one of his interviews on Russian state-funded television in April 2017.

Trump’s tariffs will fuel price increases and limit growth, Powell forecasts

BY **RACHEL SIEGEL**

President Donald Trump’s tariffs are “highly likely” to spur a temporary rise in inflation, Federal Reserve Board Chair Jerome H. Powell said Wednesday, cautioning that those effects could end up being longer-lasting — prompting markets to slide and extend day-long losses.

Speaking before the Economic Club of Chicago, Powell said more persistent risks to inflation depend on how much tariffs end up affecting the economy and how long it takes trade policy to pass through to prices. Investors grew nervous throughout Powell’s remarks, especially because there is so much uncertainty around how long the inflation could last, triggering a market sell-off.



ERIN HOOLEY/AP

The Federal Reserve’s Jerome H. Powell speaks in Chicago.

By market close, the Dow Jones Industrial Average was down roughly 700 points, or 1.7 percent, and the S&P 500 had fallen 2.2 percent. The tech-heavy Nasdaq composite index, which has borne the weight of the trade war in particular, was down 3 percent.

SEE **POWELL** ON **A18**

IN THE NEWS

Alien ‘biosignature’ NASA’s James Webb Space Telescope detected a possible signature of life on a world 124 light-years away. **A5**

Eastern hellbenders Virginia scientists are working to save the salamander decimated after Hurricane Helene struck and caused some of the worst flooding in decades. **B1**

THE NATION **David Hogg**, DNC vice chair, announced plans to primary members of his own party. **A3**
A proposed rule would narrow the definition of “harm” for habitats of endangered species. **A9**

THE WORLD **Russian missiles** hit civilians in Ukraine as the military held a near-by awards ceremony. **A11**
Europe is pinning its U.S. trade hopes on Italy’s right-wing prime minister. **A12**

THE ECONOMY **Beijing** is working to stoke domestic demand as it faces the loss of U.S. consumers in the escalating trade war. **A14**
Home builders are gloomy over tariffs and economic uncertainty, with some already seeing higher prices for goods. **A14**

THE REGION **In Virginia**, big money is already funneling into races for governor, lieutenant governor, attorney general and House of Delegates. **B1**
VMI selected as interim president as Youngkin donor who quit in 2020 ahead of a vote on a Confederate statue. **B1**

STYLE **The White House** has eliminated a permanent spot for wire services in the press pool. **C1**
LOCAL LIVING **To declutter**, start tiny. “Microparing,” or tossing two items a day, can offer a reward of dopamine on par with retail therapy.

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